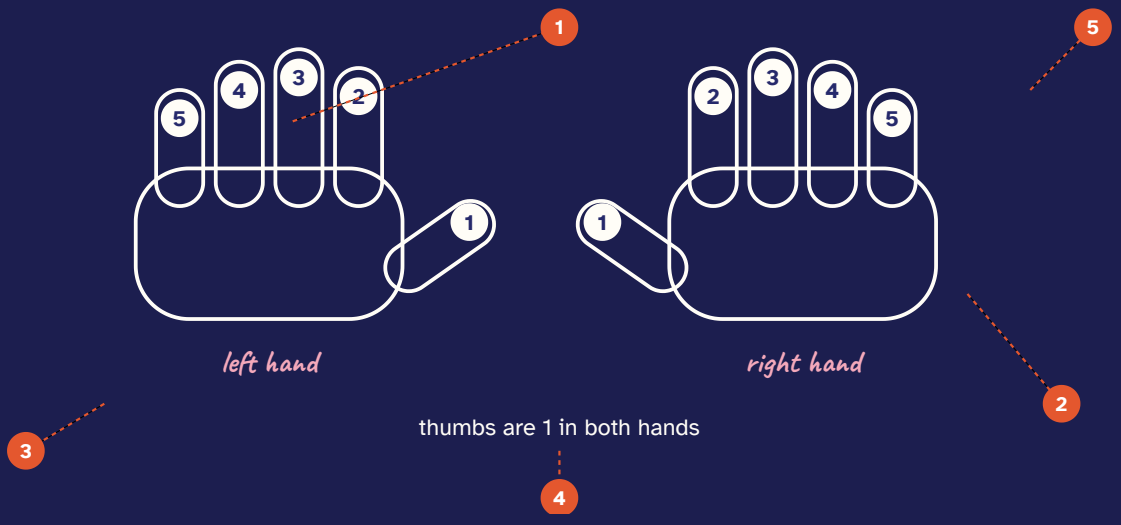
PART VIII · AT THE PIANO

Playing and listening

Everything before this page is knowledge. This part turns it into playing: the right fingers, practice that works, reading at sight, a trained ear, and the calm to perform.



1 **Fingering** p. 163
finger numbers, five-finger positions, thumb under

2 **Practising well** p. 165
slow, small chunks, then put it back together

3 **Sight-reading** p. 167
scan first, keep going, read ahead

4 **Listening** p. 169
clap it back, high or low, major or minor

5 **Performing** p. 171
warm up, start calmly, keep going after a slip

★ **Tips: when practice isn't working** p. 173

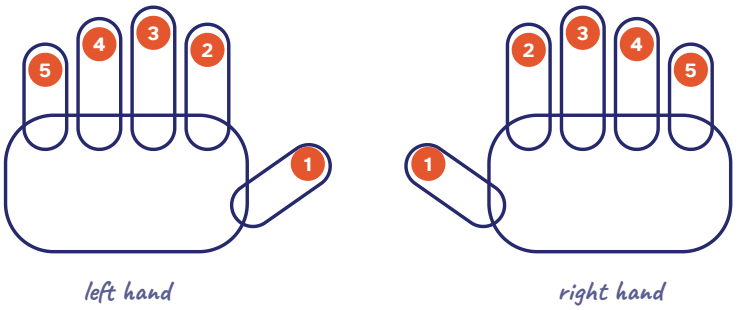
PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · 1

Fingering

Each finger has a number, the same in both hands: the thumb is 1, the little finger 5. Good fingering is planned, not guessed: choose it once, write it in, and use it every time.
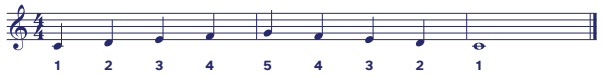
THE SECRET

Thumbs are 1 in both hands. Choose a fingering once, write it in, keep it.
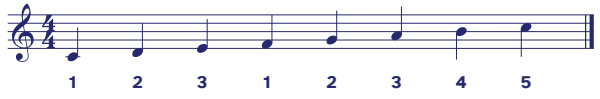


Thumbs are 1 in both hands

Five-finger position
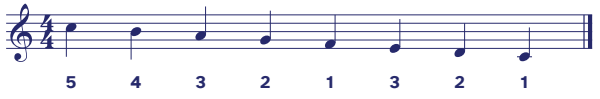


Thumb on C, one finger on each key up to G: five notes without moving the hand. Many first pieces stay in one position.

Thumb under, finger over



Up the scale: 1 2 3, thumb under to F, then 1 2 3 4 5.



Down: 5 4 3 2 1, then 3 crosses over the thumb.
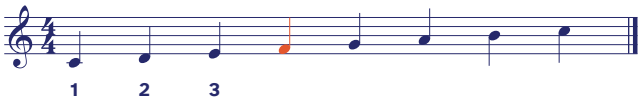
TWO-MINUTE DRILL Play C D E F G with each hand, saying the finger numbers: right 1 2 3 4 5 up, left 5 4 3 2 1 up. Then both hands together.

Left hand, C major up: 5 4 3 2 1, then 3 crosses over to A, then 2 1. **Down:** 1 2 3, thumb under to F, then 1 2 3 4 5.

PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · 1 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Which finger plays the F?



?

1. **C D E** are 1 2 3.
2. **The F:** finger 4, or the thumb tucked under?
3. **Then** how do you reach the top C?

The **thumb** passes under to F; then 2 3 4 5 reach the top C.

EXAMPLE 2

Which finger plays G?

Right hand, thumb on C ?

1. **Thumb on C** is 1.
2. **Count up** one finger per key: D, E, F, G.
3. **So G** is…?

Finger **5**: C D E F G is 1 2 3 4 5.

GAME
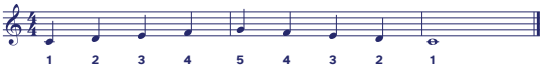
Name the finger

1 thumb	2 index
3 middle	4 little

Give the finger number.

Answer: 1 one · 2 two · 3 three · 4 five.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Five fingers, five keys.

Right hand on C D E F G. Play up and down, saying the finger numbers aloud. Then the left hand: 5 4 3 2 1 from C up.

TRAP

- × Changing fingering every time you play: choose one, write it in, keep it.
- × Landing heavily on the thumb as it passes under: let it glide.

SEE ALSO

The keyboard p. 22 · Major scales p. 93

PRACTISE IT

Online: Scales with fingering

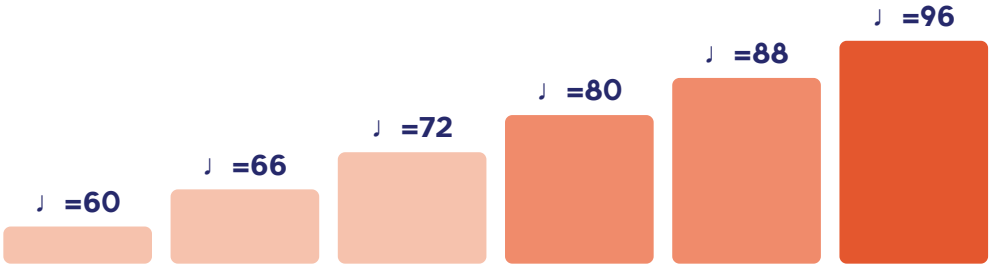
PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · 2

Practising well

Practice is not playing a piece again and again from the top. It is fixing the hard bits, slowly and correctly, then joining them back together.

THE SECRET

Slow, small, and correct; then a little faster; then join the pieces.



three correct times at one speed, then one step up

Slow and correct, one step at a time

A fifteen-minute plan

TIME	WHAT YOU DO
2 min	warm up: a scale or five-finger exercise
5 min	the hardest bars, slowly, hands separately
5 min	join the bars, hands together, still slow
3 min	play the whole section; mark what slipped

Four tools

TOOL	HOW
small chunks	one bar, or two, plus the first note of the next
hands separately	each hand alone until it is easy, then together
slow, then faster	the metronome ladder: three correct times, then one notch up
count aloud	say the beats: it keeps the rhythm honest

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER
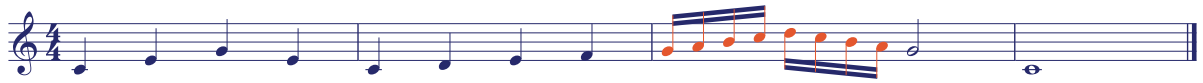
Practise in rhythms

For a run of even quavers, play it long–short, then short–long, slowly. When you go back to even notes, the run is suddenly easier: every note has been the “long” one.

PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · 2 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Which bar first?



1. **Play it through once.** Where did it slip?
2. **The semiquavers** in bar 3: hardest?
3. **Start there**, slowly.

Bar 3, the semiquavers: practise the **hardest bar first**, slowly, then join bars 2–4.

EXAMPLE 2

When do you speed up?

♩ =60: right, right, wrong ?

1. **How many correct** in a row do you need?
2. **After a mistake**, start counting again.
3. **Then** one notch up.

Not yet: three **correct** in a row at 60, then try 66.

GAME

Good habit or not?

1	2
from the top	hardest first
3	4
faster to fix	slow, correct

Which help?

Answer: 2 and 4 help; 1 and 3 waste time.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

60 → 66 → 72

Climb the ladder.

Pick one hard bar. Play it three times correctly at a slow speed, then one notch faster. Stop when it slips twice.

HOW TO

Keep a practice log

1. **Write the date** and what you practised.
2. **Note one thing** that got better and one that did not.
3. **Start tomorrow** with the one that did not.

THINK OF IT Practice is like building a wall: lay each brick straight and the wall stands on its own.

TRAP

- × Practising mistakes: playing fast and wrong teaches your fingers the wrong notes.
- × Only playing what you already know: spend most time on the hard bits.

SEE ALSO
Speed words p. 82 · Fingering p. 163

PRACTISE IT
Online: Metronome · Practice log
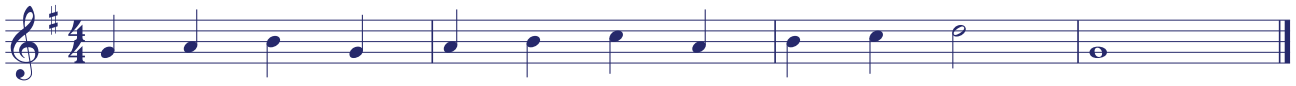
PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · 3

Sight-reading

Sight-reading is playing music you have never seen. The secret is a short look first, then keeping the beat going whatever happens: a wrong note passes, a stop is heard by everyone.

THE SECRET

Look before you play, then never stop: the beat matters more than any note.



Thirty seconds first: one sharp (G major), 4/4, starts on G, steps up in a pattern.
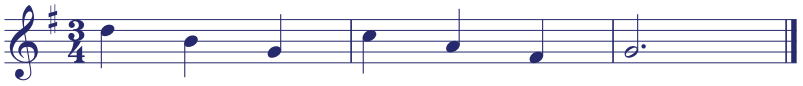
Look first, then never stop

The thirty-second scan

CHECK	LOOK FOR
1 key	sharps or flats at the start
2 time	the time signature: count a bar before you start
3 clefs and notes	the first note in each hand; the lowest and highest
4 rhythm	the trickiest rhythm: tap it
5 patterns	steps, skips, repeats, sequences
6 marks	dynamics, slurs, speed words

EXAMPLE 1

What do you check first?



?

1 **The key:** how many sharps? 2 **The time:** how many beats? 3 **The F in bar 2:** F or F♯?

G major, 3/4. The F in bar 2 is **F♯**, from the key signature. Count “1 2 3” and go.

EXAMPLE 2

A wrong note in bar 2: now what?

Stop and fix it, or keep going? ?
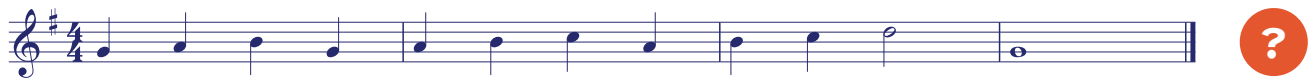
1 **Is the beat** still going? 2 **What does a listener** notice more? 3 **So?**

Keep going: catch the next beat. A stop is heard far more than a wrong note.

PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

Spot the pattern



1. **Bar 1:** what shape?
2. **Bar 2:** the same shape, where?
3. **So**, how much do you really need to read?

A **sequence**: bar 2 is bar 1 a step higher. Read the shape, not every note.

GAME

Scan order

1 rhythm

2 key
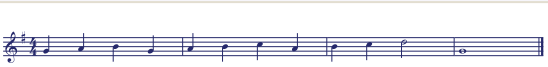
3 time

4 patterns

Put the four checks in the order of the scan.

Answer: key · time · rhythm · patterns.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



One new piece a day.

Pick something easy: scan for thirty seconds, then play it once, slowly, without stopping. Only then go back.

HOW TO

Read ahead

1. **While you play** one bar, let your eyes move to the next.
2. **Practise it:** cover each bar with a card as you play it.
3. **Read shapes** (steps, skips, chords), not single notes.

THINK OF IT Sight-reading is like reading aloud: you look a few words ahead, and if you trip on one, the sentence goes on.

TRAP

- × Choosing a speed you cannot keep: sight-read slowly.
- × Looking down at your hands: keep your eyes on the music.
- × Skipping the scan: thirty seconds of looking saves many wrong notes.

SEE ALSO

Reading the notes p. 32 · Repetition and sequence p. 150

PRACTISE IT

Online: Sight-reading trainer

PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · 4

Listening

Your ear is a musical instrument too. Train it in small steps: clap a rhythm back, sing a tune back, then hear whether music goes up or down, is major or minor, and whether it has finished.
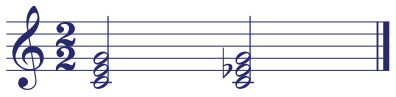
THE SECRET

Sing it back first: if you can sing it, you can play it.



Questions for your ear

Major or minor?



C E G, then C E♭ G: bright, then darker.

Only the middle note changes. Major usually sounds bright and open, minor darker or sadder. Sing the middle note of each and hear it drop.

Intervals by song

INTERVAL	THE FIRST TWO NOTES OF…
major 2nd	Frère Jacques (Frè-re)
major 3rd	Oh When the Saints (Oh when)
perfect 4th	Amazing Grace (A-ma)
perfect 5th	Twinkle (twin-kle **TWIN**: the 2nd to the 3rd note)
major 6th	My Bonnie (My Bon-)
octave	Somewhere over the Rainbow (Some-where)

HOW TO
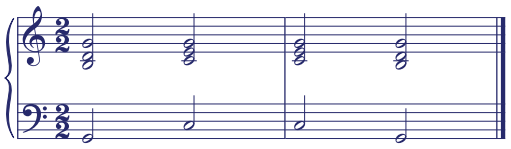
Clap it back

1. **Someone claps** a rhythm of two bars.
2. **You clap it back** straight away, keeping the beat.
3. **Then sing back** a short tune, then find it on the keys.

PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Finished or not?

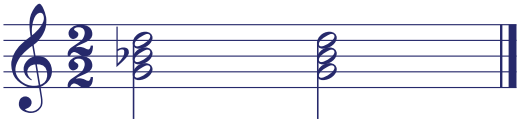


1 **Bar 1** ends on which chord? 2 **Bar 2** ends on which chord? 3 **Which ending** sounds finished?

Bar 1 ends **home** on C (a perfect cadence: finished); bar 2 stops on G (imperfect: not finished).

EXAMPLE 2

Major or minor?



1 **Play the first chord.** Bright or dark? 2 **The second?** 3 **Which note** changed?

First **minor**, then **major**: only the middle note moved, B♭ up to B.

GAME

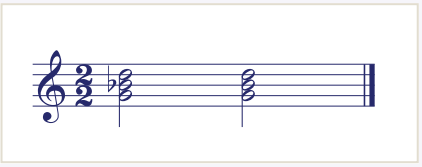
Which song?

1	2	3
5th up	octave up	4th up

Name a song with that leap near the start.

Answer: 1 Twinkle · 2 Somewhere over the Rainbow · 3 Amazing Grace.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Bright or dark?

Ask someone to play major or minor chords in any order. Say “bright” or “dark” for each. Ten in a row?

TRAP

× Guessing from the hands: close your eyes and listen.

SEE ALSO

Intervals p. 45 · Cadences p. 139

PRACTISE IT

Online: Ear trainer

PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · 5

Performing

Playing for others is a skill you can practise, like scales. Nerves are normal: they mean you care. A routine before you start and a plan for slips make them much smaller.

THE SECRET

Breathe, feel a bar of the beat, then begin. After a slip, catch the next beat.



Four steps to the first note

WHEN	WHAT YOU DO
Before	warm up your hands; practise starting, not only the whole piece; play it to a friend or family first
At the piano	adjust the bench; feet flat; breathe out; feel one bar of the beat in your head
If you slip	keep the beat going; catch the next beat or the next phrase; never go back
After	hands in your lap for a moment, stand, bow, smile

THE RULE

The listener follows the beat and the mood. Keep both going and a slip is forgotten in a second.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Every day this week, play your piece once from the start without stopping, whatever happens, as if someone were listening.

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Playing from memory

Learn it in sections and know where each starts. Memory works best when it is **four kinds at once**: the sound, the feel in your fingers, the look of the page, and knowing the chords and the form.

HOW TO

Practise performing

1. **Choose three starting places** in your piece and practise starting from each.
2. **Play it through once a day** without stopping, whatever happens.
3. **Play to someone**: a friend, family, a phone camera.

PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · 5 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

How do you start?

You sit down.
Your heart is racing. ?

1. **The bench:** right height, right distance?
2. **Your breath:** in, then out slowly.
3. **The beat:** what do you hear first?

Adjust, breathe out, and **feel one bar** of the speed in your head. Then the first note.

EXAMPLE 2

You slip in bar 5: what now?

Bar 5: a wrong note, and your hand freezes ?

1. **Do you stop** and start again?
2. **Where is the beat** now?
3. **Where can you rejoin?**

Keep counting and come back in on the **next beat**, or at the start of the next phrase. Never go back.

GAME

Help or not?

1 going back

2 breathe first

3 keep the beat

4 rush to finish

Which help a performance?

Answer: 2 and 3 help; 1 and 4 do not.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

breathe · beat · play · bow

A one-minute concert.

Choose eight bars. Walk to the piano, sit, breathe, feel a bar, play, bow. Do it for someone today.

THINK OF IT The audience wants you to do well: they are on your side from the first note.

TRAP

- × Starting before you are ready: breathe and feel the beat first.
- × Apologising with your face after a slip: keep going and nobody minds.

SEE ALSO
Practising well p. 165 · Expression p. 76

PRACTISE IT
Online: Practice log

PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · TIPS

When practice isn't working

You practise every day and it is not getting better. Usually the practice, not the player, needs fixing: too fast, too long, or always from the top.

TIP

What you notice, what to check

WHAT YOU NOTICE	CHECK	TURN TO
You stumble in the same place every time	**the fingering:** write one in and keep it	p. 163
It is fine slowly, wrong at speed	**the ladder:** three correct, then one notch up	p. 165
You play it from the top every time	**small chunks**, hardest first	p. 165
New pieces take forever to learn	**the scan:** key, time, rhythm, patterns	p. 167
You cannot hear your own mistakes	**listening:** record yourself, sing it	p. 169
It falls apart in front of people	**a routine** and practising starts	p. 171

Four ways to unstick practice

1. **Halve the speed**
   Whatever speed you use, try half. Correct and slow beats fast and wrong.

2. **Shorten the chunk**
   If two bars fail, try one. If one fails, try one beat.

3. **Take a break**
   Ten short sessions beat one long one. Your brain keeps learning between them.

4. **Ask a question**
   Write down what goes wrong, and take it to your teacher.

EXAMPLE

Ten minutes left: what do you play?

One bar you keep missing, and a whole piece you know ?

1. **Which needs the time more?**
2. **How many minutes** on the hard bar?
3. **And** the last minutes?

About **seven minutes** on the hard bar, slowly, then play the whole piece once at the end, for joy.

THINK OF IT Practice does not make perfect: perfect practice does. Slow and correct is the fastest way.